‘You tell me, you’ve got all the news.’

‘Let’s catch up after a couple of days. Meanwhile, check out the local police?’

‘Why the local police when the CBI has taken over?’

‘You never know what comes up,’ Verma said and hung up. Anirudhya understood the forensics lab leaking vital evidence to a newspaper was still fresh in the SIT’s mind.

But what did he mean by ‘catch up after a couple of days’? What would he do in the next ‘couple of days’ if he could not meet his source and get an idea of how the investigation was progressing? That, too, at the cost of five-star luxury! He sensed trouble. Dilip Bobb would be expecting his copies on a daily basis. So would Inderjit Badhwar. He checked the room, the wardrobe and the minibar; he took a look at the price list and headed for a shower.

Now he would have to look for food outside the hotel. *India Today* kept its reporters in five-star hotels but paid a daily allowance, or DA, of 200 bucks, which would no way take care of food and laundry in a five-star facility.

It was about 3 p.m., and Madras was pretty hot and sultry. *India Today*’s Madras office was within walking distance from the hotel. Anirudhya dropped at an Udupi café and ordered a non-veg thali. Having spent five years in college in the city, he was familiar with the local cuisine. But today it was not to his taste. Something was wrong. He cleared the bill and got up. Nothing had been going right since he had landed.

Finding the Madras office on Binny Road was, however, easy. He pushed the swing door inwards, introduced himself and asked for Anand Viswanathan and Kavitha Shetty. Those were the only two names from the Madras bureau he knew. Both had gone out on assignments. Madras was under the lens of the world since the assassination. The action was outside and not inside a journalist’s office. He was about to leave and get back to the hotel when someone called out to him.

‘Anirudhya?’ a stocky, handsome guy with a thick moustache asked.

‘Yes?’